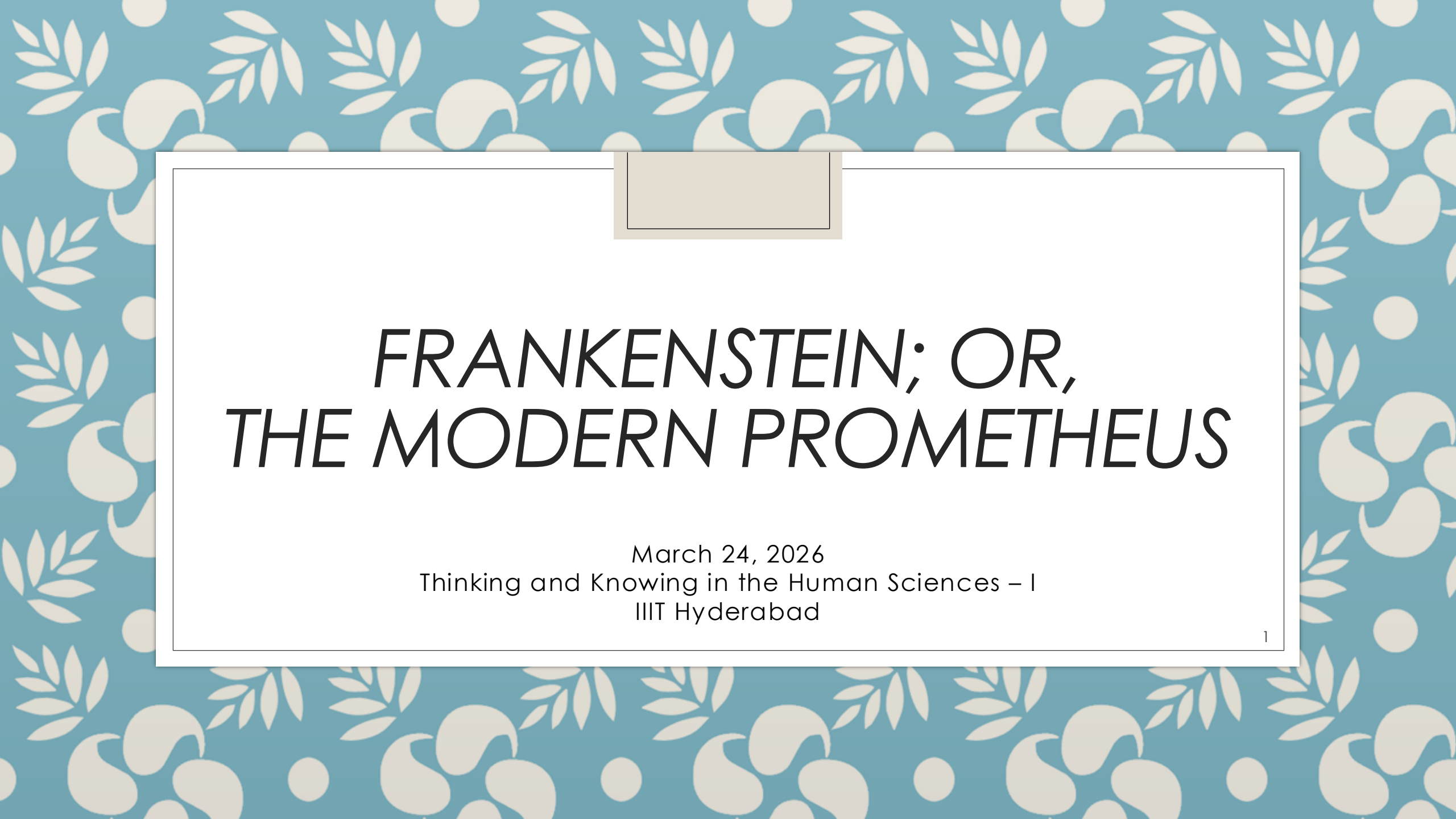




# *FRANKENSTEIN; OR, THE MODERN PROMETHEUS*

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Thinking and Knowing in the Human Sciences – I  
IIIT Hyderabad

# By a Lady ...

- Jane Austen did not publish her novels in her own name.
- Mary Shelley published *Frankenstein* anonymously.

## Why?

***“Two other friends (a tale from the pen of one of whom would be far more acceptable to the public than any thing I can ever hope to produce) ...”***

# The Preface

- The Preface makes it clear that this Shelley was part of a larger dialogue/debate on these matters (science, religion, ethics) and that this book is part of that dialogue/debate as well.
  - Mentions Darwin; implicit: Byron and P.B. Shelley, a conversation in Geneva in 1816
- ***“the novelty of the situations which it develops” (1)***
- ***“partly as a source of amusement, and partly as an expedient for exercising any untried resources of mind” (1)***

***“endeavoured to preserve the truth of the elementary principles of human nature, while I have not scrupled to innovate upon their combinations” (1).***

- Defence: some of the greatest writers (mentions Homer, Shakespeare, and Milton) have done the same. **Implications?**

***“the most humble novelist, who seeks to confer or received amusements from his labours, may, without presumption, apply to prose fiction a license, or rather a rule, from the adoption of which so many exquisite combinations of human feeling have resulted in the highest specimens of poetry” (1).***





Napoleon Crossing the Alps (1801) by Jacques-Louis David  
Oil on canvas



Bonaparte Crossing the Alps (1848-1850) by Paul Delaroche  
Oil on canvas











# Romanticism

- IDEALIZED view of the world
- Beauty, Expression, Sensibility, Imagination, Intuition
- Impact on Nationalism:
  - Sense of national sentiment formed through a shared collective heritage, a common cultural past, accessible through folk culture and past cultural artefacts (epics, songs).





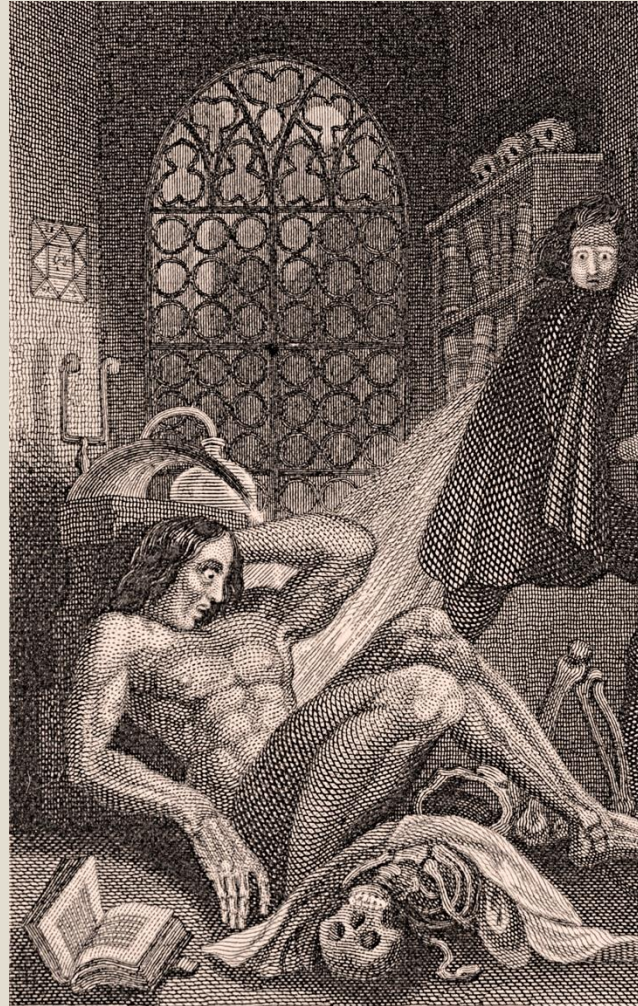
# Romanticism

- Idea of the lone, tormented genius/hero, e.g. Napoleon – a national hero
- Revolution: liberty, equality, fraternity; the idea of a nation being its people
- Emphasis on the individual; mysterious bond between Man and Nature.
- Fascination with the supernatural and the occult.



# The Gothic

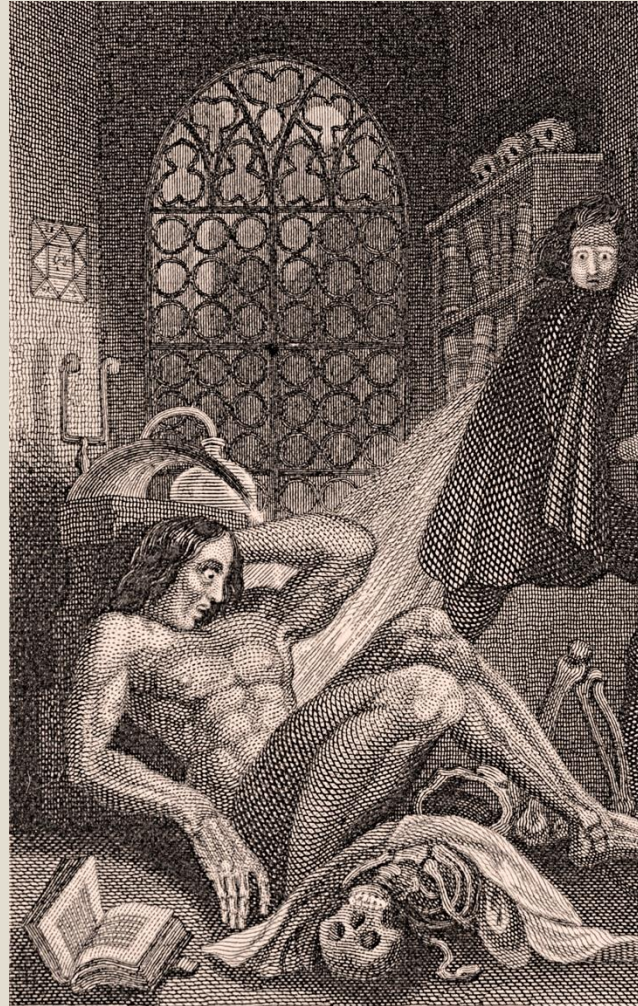
- Mystery and Fear
- Omens, curses, prophecy
- Atmosphere
- Suspense
- Supernatural and Paranormal Activity
- Passionate romance
- Anti-Hero
- Damsel in distress
- Nightmares and Visions
- Extreme emotions and psychological trauma
- Powerful, autocratic male villain





# The Gothic

- Shelley's *Frankenstein* and Bram Stoker's *Dracula* are classic examples of the genre.
- Hierarchy between Romanticism and Gothic: Romanticism believed to be a male preserve, while the "sensationalist" Gothic was attributed to women authors.



- What Romantic elements have you observed in *Frankenstein*?
- How do we place the Letters by Walton to his sister in the context of the larger story?



*“What may not be expected in a country of eternal light? I may there discover the wondrous power which attracts the needle and may regulate a thousand celestial observations that require only this voyage to render their seeming eccentricities consistent for ever. I shall satiate my ardent curiosity with the sight of a part of the world never before visited, and may tread a land never before imprinted by the foot of man. These are my enticements, and they are sufficient to conquer all fear of danger or death and to induce me to commence this laborious voyage with the joy a child feels when he embarks in a little boat, with his holiday mates, on an expedition of discovery up his native river. But supposing all these conjectures to be false, you cannot contest the inestimable benefit which I shall confer on all mankind, to the last generation, by discovering a passage near the pole to those countries, to reach which at present so many months are requisite; or by ascertaining the secret of the magnet, which, if at all possible, can only be effected by an undertaking such as mine.*

*These reflections have dispelled the agitation with which I began my letter, and I feel my heart glow with an enthusiasm which elevates me to heaven, for nothing contributes so much to tranquillise the mind as a steady purpose—a point on which the soul may fix its intellectual eye.”*

*“My life might have been passed in ease and luxury, but I preferred glory to every enticement that wealth placed in my path.”*



***“I cannot describe to you my sensations on the near prospect of my undertaking. It is impossible to communicate to you a conception of the trembling sensation, half pleasurable and half fearful, with which I am preparing to depart. I am going to unexplored regions, to ‘the land of mist and snow,’ but I shall kill no albatross; therefore do not be alarmed for my safety or if I should come back to you as worn and woeful as the ‘Ancient Mariner.’ You will smile at my allusion, but I will disclose a secret. I have often attributed my attachment to, my passionate enthusiasm for, the dangerous mysteries of ocean to that production of the most imaginative of modern poets. There is something at work in my soul which I do not understand. I am practically industrious—painstaking, a workman to execute with perseverance and labour—but besides this there is a love for the marvellous, a belief in the marvellous, intertwined in all my projects, which hurries me out of the common pathways of men, even to the wild sea and unvisited regions I am about to explore.”***

- Why does Walton seek a friend?



*“I have no one near me, gentle yet courageous, possessed of a cultivated as well as of a capacious mind, whose tastes are like my own, to approve or amend my plans. How would such a friend repair the faults of your poor brother! I am too ardent in execution and too impatient of difficulties.”*

*“Even broken in spirit as he is, no one can feel more deeply than he does the beauties of nature. The starry sky, the sea, and every sight afforded by these wonderful regions seem still to have the power of elevating his soul from earth. Such a man has a double existence: he may suffer misery and be overwhelmed by disappointments, yet when he has retired into himself, he will be like a celestial spirit that has a halo around him, within whose circle no grief or folly ventures.”*

# The Depiction of Arts and Sciences

*“I delighted in investigating the facts relative to the actual world; she busied herself in following the aërial creations of the poets. The world was to me a secret, which I desired to discover; to her it was a vacancy, which she sought to people with imaginations of her own” (26).*



- How does Victor Frankenstein begin his journey in natural philosophy? How do different people react to his approach?
- What are the goals he is fascinated by in his study of natural philosophy? Which of these attracts him the most?
- How does his discovery of distillation, the effects of steam, and electricity affect his views on his favourite natural philosophers?
- Why is Henry Clerval not allowed to go to Ingolstadt?

*“... the powers of the latter were chimerical, while those of the former were real and practical ...”*

*“... in compliance with his favourite theory, that learning was superfluous in the commerce of ordinary life. Henry had a refined mind; he had no desire to be idle, and was well pleased to become his father’s partner, but he believed that a man might be a very good trader, and yet possess a cultivated understanding.”*

- How do Frankenstein's university teachers influence or shape his academic interests? Why is he initially reluctant to listen to their advice?
- What happens to prevent Frankenstein from leaving for Geneva?
- Why does Frankenstein not tell Walton his secret?



# Physiognomy

- M. Krempe's "repulsive physiognomy"
- "It was, perhaps, the amiable character of this man that inclined me more to that branch of natural philosophy which he professed than intrinsic love for the science itself."
- "She was now a woman in stature and expression of countenance, which was uncommonly lovely. An open and capacious forehead give indications of a good understanding, joined to great frankness of disposition. Her eyes were hazel, and expressive of mildness, now through recent affliction allied to sadness. Her hair was of a rich, dark auburn, her complexion fair, and her figure slight and graceful."

***“I had a contempt for the uses of modern natural philosophy. It was very different when the masters of the science sought immortality and power; such views, although futile, were grand; but now the scene was changed. The ambition of the inquirer seemed to limit itself to the annihilation of those visions on which my interest in science was chiefly founded. I was required to exchange chimeras of boundless grandeur for realities of little worth.”***

***“The ancient teachers of this science,” said he, “promised impossibilities and performed nothing. The modern masters promise very little; they know that metals cannot be transmuted and that the elixir of life is a chimera but these philosophers, whose hands seem only made to dabble in dirt, and their eyes to pore over the microscope or crucible, have indeed performed miracles. They penetrate into the recesses of nature and show how she works in her hiding-places. They ascend into the heavens; they have discovered how the blood circulates, and the nature of the air we breathe. They have acquired new and almost unlimited powers; they can command the thunders of heaven, mimic the earthquake, and even mock the invisible world with its own shadows.”***

*“Whence, I often asked myself, did the principle of life proceed? It was a bold question, and one which has ever been considered as a mystery; yet with how many things are we upon the brink of becoming acquainted, if cowardice or carelessness did not restrain our inquiries. I revolved these circumstances in my mind and determined thenceforth to apply myself more particularly to those branches of natural philosophy which relate to physiology.”*



*“from the midst of this darkness a sudden light broke in upon me—a light so brilliant and wondrous, yet so simple, that while I became dizzy with the immensity of the prospect which it illustrated, I was surprised that among so many men of genius who had directed their inquiries towards the same science, that I alone should be reserved to discover so astonishing a secret.*

*Remember, I am not recording the vision of a madman. The sun does not more certainly shine in the heavens than that which I now affirm is true. Some miracle might have produced it, yet the stages of the discovery were distinct and probable. After days and nights of incredible labour and fatigue, I succeeded in discovering the cause of generation and life; nay, more, I became myself capable of bestowing animation upon lifeless matter.”*

*“Life and death appeared to me ideal bounds, which I should first break through, and pour a torrent of light into our dark world. A new species would bless me as its creator and source; many happy and excellent natures would owe their being to me. No father could claim the gratitude of his child so completely as I should deserve theirs. Pursuing these reflections, I thought that if I could bestow animation upon lifeless matter, I might in process of time (although I now found it impossible) renew life where death had apparently devoted the body to corruption.”*

***“Learn from me, if not by my precepts, at least by my example, how dangerous is the acquirement of knowledge and how much happier that man is who believes his native town to be the world, than he who aspires to become greater than his nature will allow.”***

***“A human being in perfection ought always to preserve a calm and peaceful mind and never to allow passion or a transitory desire to disturb his tranquillity. I do not think that the pursuit of knowledge is an exception to this rule. If the study to which you apply yourself has a tendency to weaken your affections and to destroy your taste for those simple pleasures in which no alloy can possibly mix, then that study is certainly unlawful, that is to say, not befitting the human mind. If this rule were always observed; if no man allowed any pursuit whatsoever to interfere with the tranquillity of his domestic affections, Greece had not been enslaved, Cæsar would have spared his country, America would have been discovered more gradually, and the empires of Mexico and Peru had not been destroyed.”***



- Why does he dream of Elizabeth dead and rotting?
- Why doesn't he tell anyone about who he is convinced has killed William, and why doesn't he confess at Justine's trial and save her?
- Why does Frankenstein hate his creature so much?
- Why does Frankenstein decide to travel (for two years!)?

- What transformations do we see in the creature across the text?
- Why does Frankenstein ultimately stop his work on the female version of the “creature”?
- What is the significance of the three women (Margaret Walton, Elizabeth Lavenza, and the proposed female “creature”)?
- What are the larger questions that this text allows us to contemplate about science and its place in the world?